

Times Higher Education World University Rankings – New Zealand university results

Background

The Times Higher Education (THE) World University Rankings capture a number of broad areas of performance and have additional features other rankings do not have. This includes a measure of income sourced from industry. The 2026 rankings were released in October 2025, with the results published at: <https://www.timeshighereducation.com/world-university-rankings/latest/world-ranking>.

Between 2010-11 and 2014-15, the Times Higher Education (THE) World University Rankings were produced by Thomson Reuters for Times Higher Education. Before this, the THE rankings were produced by Quacquarelli Symonds. From 2015-16, Elsevier's Scopus database has been used to generate the research-based metrics used in the rankings.

Method and criticisms

In compiling the rankings, THE excludes universities that do not teach undergraduates, teach in a narrow subject area, or produce fewer than 1,000 indexed publications¹ over five years.

The way the rankings are determined by THE has changed over time. The methodology and/or underlying data was changed significantly in the second edition in 2011-12, in the 2015-16 edition, and in the 2024 edition. In the 2026 edition, the metrics are grouped in five broad component measures used to determine the THE rankings. These are presented in Table 1, along with the specific measures used to generate a score for each of these components.

A significant proportion of the THE ranking (33 percent) is based on surveys of academics and so may capture perceptions rather than actual performance.

The THE rankings system normalises for citation and publication performance between different subject areas when assessing research performance.

The citations measure has been criticised for not using fractional counting. When there are authors of a publication from two or more institutions THE assigns the full citation count to each of those institutions. In the case where there are multiple authors of a highly cited publication, this can distort the performance of institutions with relatively low publication counts. From the 2018 edition, the citation measure adjusts for when there are more than 1,000 authors in an attempt to reduce the distortion caused

by these papers, which are generally highly cited. The methodology introduced in 2024 included three new metrics that increased the weight of highly-cited papers and patents.

Table 1

Component measures used in Times Higher Education World University Rankings

Criteria	Indicator
Teaching (29.5%)	Reputational survey of academics (15%) Ratio of Doctorates awarded over academic staff (5.5%) Staff to student ratio (4.5%) Institutional income/academic staff (2.5%) Ratio of Doctorates awarded over bachelors degrees awarded (2.0%)
Research Environment (29%)	Reputational survey of academics (18%) Research income/academic staff (5.5%) Research productivity: scholarly publications/academic and research staff (5.5%)
Research Quality (30%)	Citation impact (15%) Research strength: 75 th percentile of citations (5%) Research excellence: number of papers in the top 10% worldwide (5%) Research influence: importance of papers (5%)
Industry (4%)	Industry income: Research income from industry/academic staff (2%) Patents: number of patents that cite research conducted by that university (2%)
International outlook (7.5%)	Proportion of international students (2.5%) Proportion of international staff (2.5%) International collaboration: scholarly publications with one or more international co-authors/total scholarly publications (2.5%)

¹ Publications include indexed: articles, reviews, conference proceedings and books. The latter was added in 2016-17.

Results

Table 2 presents the rankings for New Zealand universities in the THE World University Rankings. Although the THE World University Rankings have been published in their current form for 15 years, the methodology and/or underlying data was changed significantly in the second edition in 2011-12, in the 2015-16 edition, and in the 2024 edition.

Between 2010-11 and 2014-15, THE only published the rankings of the top 400 universities. Since then, THE has been increasing the number of institutions with a published ranking which has resulted in more New Zealand universities appearing in the ranking. For the 2025 edition, the rankings of 2,191 institutions were published.

Some of the key points of the THE rankings for New Zealand universities are:

- ▲ In 2026, all eight New Zealand universities were ranked by Times Higher Education in the top 800.
- ▲ The University of Auckland is the top-ranked New Zealand university.

Table 2
Times Higher Education World University Rankings for New Zealand universities

University	2010-11	Change in method	2011-12	2012-13	2013-14	2014-15	Change in underlying data	2015-16	2016-17	2018	2019	2020	2021	2022	2023	Change in underlying data and method	2024	2025	2026
Auckland	145=		173=	161	164=	175=		172=	165=	192	201-250	179=	147=	137=	139=		150=	152=	156=
Otago	226-250		201-225	226-250	226-250	251-275		201-250	201-250	201-250	201-250	201-250	201-250	201-250	301-350		301-350	351-400	351-400
Waikato			301-350	301-350	301-350	351-400		401-500	401-500	351-400	401-500	501-600	501-600	401-500	401-500		401-500	401-500	401-500
VUW	226-250		251-275	251-275	276-300	276-300		351-400	351-400	401-500	401-500	501-600	501-600	501-600	401-500		401-500	401-500	401-500
AUT								601-800	501-600	401-500	301-350	251-300	251-300	201-250	251-300		401-500	401-500	501-600
Lincoln									401-500	501-600	501-600	501-600	601-800	501-600	401-500		401-500	501-600	501-600
Massey	276-300		351-400	351-400				501-600	401-500	401-500	501-600	501-600	601-800	601-800	601-800		501-600	501-600	501-600
Canterbury	226-250		301-350	301-350	301-350	301-350		401-500	351-400	351-400	301-350	301-350	401-500	501-600	601-800		501-600	501-600	601-800

Notes: 1. AUT = Auckland University of Technology, VUW = Victoria University of Wellington. 2. THE has a naming convention where it assigns a year to the name of the ranking that is one year in advance of when it was actually published. For example, the 2026 THE World University Rankings were actually released in October 2025.
Source: <https://www.timeshighereducation.com/world-university-rankings/latest/world-ranking>

Tertiary System Performance Analysis
Te Pou Kaupapahere | Policy
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